

go away. There was no longer any good place to safely hit into.

Now I would teach a one-handed backhand only as a change-up. Martina and Pete Sampras still think serve-and-volley is the way to go, but that has become a change-up, too. And would it really have been wise to consistently serve and volley to hitters and movers like Serena and Venus?

That's why when a player like Carlos Alcaraz comes along and wants to use every inch of the court, play each point differently, and surprise us with his imagination, he breathes life into the game and its possibilities.

You coined the phrase 'Big Babe Tennis' when young superstars Monica Seles and Steffi Graf slugged it out during the early 1990s. That stylistic description fits the *crème de la crème* of women's tennis now more than ever, with heavyweights Aryna Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek, Coco Gauff, Amanda Anisimova, and Elena Rybakina banging big serves and heavy groundstrokes as they vie for supremacy. What are your thoughts about women's tennis today and its future?

I think current women's tennis will look like this for a long time. When I was growing up, watching the women play, it was almost all serve and volley, as it was with the men. As I said earlier, power is the coin of the realm now. Most women's matches get decided on the baseline by big hitting and spinning, and a lot of the women have better return games than serve games. The first serve percentage and the quality of the second serve is what I look for at the start of almost all women's matches. Also, their footwork and foot speed. You must be so strong, fast, and fit to live on the court with the best women players now. The game is so much about physicality that the days of teen phenoms infiltrating tennis seem pretty much impossible, no?



Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner have collided to create the most spectacular battles in the tennis universe. What do you find most striking and appealing about their riveting rivalry?

Just about everything! How respectful they are of each other. How each makes the other want to be better, more complete, the very best version of themselves. How solid and stable the people around them are.

It reminds me of Roger Federer's choice in his team. How well they understand the court and its possibilities. How they know that the only way to stay in the rivalry is to rival the other's ambitions and talents. How humble they are. How dedicated they are to bringing tennis to heights the sport has never before reached.

How you watch them and wonder how any tennis player in the future can possibly build on this and get even better than Sinner and Alcaraz already are.

You'll be inducted into the Hall of Fame with Federer. What stands out most about him both as a player and an ambassador for tennis?

It's Roger's elegance, on and off the court, isn't it? He makes hard things look supremely simple. He had all the time in the world, on and off the court. He never seemed rushed and was rarely angry on the court, and in press conferences, usually in three languages, he answered the same damn questions over and over again with patience and grace. Grace. If I only had one word to explain Roger, it would be grace.